

The Anchor We Cannot See

By Michael Bruhn

“This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, a hope both sure and steadfast and one which enters within the veil.”

Hebrews 6:19, NASB1995

Sailors have trusted anchors for thousands of years. The earliest were little more than massive stones. Later came wooden anchors weighted with lead, then iron anchors with arms and flukes designed to dig into the bottom and hold. By the time of the New Testament, ships carried multiple anchors because sailors knew something every boater still knows: **When the wind and current begin deciding where your boat is going, you need something stronger than the wind and current.**

Paul knew that firsthand. In Acts 27, his ship had been driven by a storm for fourteen nights. The sailors began taking soundings: twenty fathoms, then fifteen. They knew they were being pushed toward the rocks, so they **dropped four anchors from the stern and prayed for daylight.** Those were real anchors—heavy, physical, desperate. Paul mentions anchors several times in that account, but he never turns them into a spiritual metaphor.

Then we come to Hebrews, and Scripture gives us something extraordinary: **“an anchor of the soul.”** The Greek word translated anchor is *ἄγκυρα*, *ankyra*. And yes, there is a small irony here: the book is called Hebrews, but it was written in Greek, not Hebrew. The word *ankyra* is not a special theological word. It is the ordinary Greek word for a ship’s anchor, the same kind of object we see in Acts 27. Hebrews takes that very practical piece of seamanship and gives it a spiritual force found nowhere else in Scripture: hope becomes the anchor of the human soul.

The Greek text then calls this anchor *ἀσφαλῆ* and *βεβαίαν*: sure, secure, dependable, steadfast. The emphasis is not on how tightly we can hold onto the anchor. It is on the reliability of the anchor itself. The Bible speaks many times about ships and storms, but here the anchor becomes something more: hope—not vague optimism, but hope secured in Jesus Christ.

I understand that image differently because of Jackie. When our daughter Jackie died at nineteen, Barbara and I entered waters we never wanted to sail. There are storms a boater can prepare for. You watch the forecast, secure the lines, check the engines, and set the anchor. And then there are storms for which there is no checklist. Losing Jackie was one of those. Nothing stopped that storm from coming. Nothing made the grief small. But something kept us from being carried away. **Our anchor held.**

And here is what I find remarkable about an anchor: **you trust what you cannot see.** Once I lower my anchor from *Jackie B III*, it disappears beneath the water. I cannot see the bottom. I cannot watch the flukes dig in. But I can feel the rode come tight. The boat swings, the strain increases, and then she stops drifting.

That is sometimes what faith feels like. I cannot see heaven. I cannot see Jackie. I cannot see everything God is doing. But I can feel the pull of His promises.

Hebrews says our anchor goes “within the veil.” That turns the whole nautical picture upside down. Normally an anchor goes down. This one goes up. Our hope is fastened somewhere beyond

our sight, in the presence of God. And Hebrews immediately tells us who is there: **Jesus has gone there before us.**

That is why my hope concerning Jackie does not rest merely in photographs, memories, or even in the boat that carries her name. Those things are precious. But they are not my anchor. **Jesus is.**

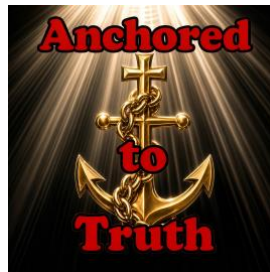
Jackie B III carries our daughter's name across rivers, bays, sounds, and open water. But Jackie herself is not lost somewhere beyond the horizon. Because of Christ, I believe she has simply reached the harbor before us.

And until our own voyage is finished, there will be days when the wind rises, when the rode stretches tight, and when I cannot see what is holding me. But every sailor knows: **tension on the rode does not mean the anchor has failed.** Sometimes it means the anchor has taken hold.

That may be what grief has taught me most. I still feel the pull. I still miss Jackie. But beneath that grief is something stronger. Christ is risen. God is faithful. Death is not final. And our hope is secured beyond the veil.

So when I see the name *Jackie B III* across the stern, I see more than the name of a daughter we lost. I see a reminder of where my anchor is set—not beneath the boat, not in this world, but in Christ.

Sure. Steadfast. And holding.



References

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<https://jackieb3.netlify.app/>